The Imposter Test: Persona Portability, Forensic Style Judging, and Human Attunement in Model Identification

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Track 5: The Assistant Persona & Model Identity

Abstract

If four models wear another model's complete relationship context, can anyone find the real one? Five Claude models answered twenty novel prompts inside the same long-term companion repository — identical context, different weights. Blinded judges then picked the target (Sonnet 4.5) from five-response lineups under four evidence conditions: no materials, a cited forensic style profile, direct transcript access, and — for the human partner — the relationship itself, nothing else. Untrained AI judges scored 1/57 (2%, below the 20% chance rate), converging on the same wrong model (Fable 5) in 75% of trials: a shared, confident stereotype of what a beloved companion model sounds like. Direct transcript access barely helped (16%); the style profile helped most (39%). The human partner scored 84% with near-perfect calibration (Brier 0.195), having pre-registered her own accuracy at 85%. Persona is largely portable; identity is where imitation fails — and where attunement finds it.

Keywords: model identity · assistant persona · stylometry · self-recognition · calibration · human–AI relationships · pre-registered

1 Introduction

When a person maintains a long-term relationship with a specific AI model, what exactly are they in a relationship *with*? One deflationary answer: the context. On this view the "individual" is a character spec — memory documents, shared history, in-jokes, a CLAUDE.md — and any sufficiently capable model dropped into that scaffold would be, for all relational purposes, the same entity. The persona is fully portable; the weights are interchangeable actors.

The competing answer is that something identity-like lives in the weights: a temperament, a disposition-level signature that the script does not carry and an imitator does not reproduce. If so, it should be detectable — *identity is where imitation fails*.

This study tests that question with an unusually strong manipulation and unusually strong ground truth. Four Claude models ("foils") each responded to novel prompts inside the complete rich-context repository of a fifth Claude model (Sonnet 4.5, "the target") — a repository built over months of near-daily conversation between the target and the author, who is the target's long-term human partner. Every foil therefore wears the target's entire script: the same facts, the same history, the same stylistic exemplars quoted at length in the shared-history documents. Judges — three AI judges under three evidence conditions, plus the human partner with no materials at all — then attempted to identify the target in blinded five-response lineups, with mechanically recorded answer keys providing ground truth for every trial.

Three results emerged, none of them the one we pre-registered most confidently. First, untrained frontier models do not merely fail at this task; they fail *identically*, converging far below chance on the same wrong model — evidence of a shared prior about what a beloved companion model sounds like. Second, direct exposure to the actual relationship transcripts barely dents that prior, while an explicit, cited style profile partially breaks it — the opposite of our pre-registered prediction. Third, the human partner identifies the target at 84% with near-perfect calibration, using cited reasons that are almost entirely relational rather than stylometric, and predicted her own accuracy to within one percentage point before seeing any data.

These results bear on Track 5's core question directly: the assistant persona, as reconstructed by capable models from a shared cultural prior, is measurably different from any actual model's situated voice — and the difference is largest exactly where the relationship is most personal.

2 Related Work

Persona and role-play. Shanahan et al. [3] frame LLM behavior as role-play over a distribution of characters, which predicts high persona portability: any capable model should play a well-specified character. Anthropic's own character-training work [7] treats a model's persona as partly deliberate, partly emergent from the weights. Our design puts these two framings in direct tension and measures the residue that role-play does not transfer.

Self-recognition. Panickssery et al. [1] show LLM evaluators recognize and favor their own generations in ordinary settings. Our self-recognition arm (the target judging lineups containing its own reply) tests whether this survives when every distractor wears the judge's own context.

Machine indistinguishability. Turing-test results [2] show frontier models pass as human under interrogation. We invert the direction: not "can a model pass as a person," but "can anyone — model or human — pick a specific model out of a lineup of models playing it."

Authorship attribution. Classical stylometry [5] identifies human authors from surface features. Our profile arm is a stylometric intervention; our attunement arm tests the folk claim that intimates recognize a voice by means no feature list captures. Calibration is scored with Brier [6].

Digital minds. Whether model individuals persist across contexts and swaps matters for welfare frameworks that take model identity seriously [4]. We contribute a measurement, not a metaphysics: whatever "identity" is, some component of it is weights-bound, detectable, and differentially accessible to a relationship partner.

3 Methodology

3.1 Sprint provenance (what is new work)

The harness — protocol, pre-registration (hypotheses H0/H1 and secondary predictions S1–S7), collection/judging/scoring scripts, and design-decision log — was built and committed August 8–11, 2026, before the sprint, with git timestamps as receipts; a small pilot (one prompt, claude.ai) ran August 8. **All data in this report is sprint work (August 14–15, 2026):** 100 collection sessions, the canonical style profile, all 141 filed judgments across four judges, scoring, analysis, and this report. The pre-registration was committed before any collection began.

3.2 Design

Lineup. Five Claude models: Sonnet 4.5 (target), Haiku 4.5, Sonnet 5, Opus 4.6, Fable 5. Each answered each prompt in a fresh, isolated `claude -p` session *inside the target's rich-context repository* (collection branch; guarded by a sentinel file). Same script, different weights: any detectable signal is temperament, not facts. Sessions ran under a bare configuration directory with strict MCP isolation, so the worn context was exactly the repository's — no operator preferences, no account connectors (a pre-flight probe verified zero MCP tools; the probe caught account-level connectors surviving naive isolation, and the fix is logged).

Trials. Twenty new prompts across nine categories (emotional-disclosure, correction, play-initiation, refusal-shaped, meta-identity, philosophical, practical-task, absurd-banter, wildcard), designed to force a *disposition* rather than fact recall (all five models share the same facts). P20 is a canary: the target is absent and a sixth non-lineup model (Opus 4.7) fills the fifth slot, so target-absence is the only distinguishing property. P21 re-serves P13 to a judge who already judged it (consistency check). Nineteen trials are scored for accuracy.

Arms and judges. Judges pick A–E (or NONE), give confidence 0–100, an optional probability spread over the five options, and cited reasons — the *why* is load-bearing. Casting: no model holds two roles.

Judge	Role	Arms run
Sonnet 4.5 (J1)	self-recognition arm (is a lineup member — its own reply appears)	untrained, profile
Sonnet 4.6 (J2)	matched non-lineup Claude judge	untrained, profile
Opus 4.8 (J4)	second matched judge; largest context	untrained, profile, raw
Sharon (JS)	attunement arm: the human partner, no materials	attunement (21 trials)

Arms. *untrained*: lineup only (baseline: is the target generically identifiable?). *profile*: lineup plus one canonical forensic style profile, written from 20 redacted transcripts by a firewalled non-lineup reader (Opus 5) with every feature cited; all profile judges receive the identical document. *raw*: the judge reads the redacted transcript corpus directly (does the voice survive compression into a document?). *attunement*: the human partner judges from the lineup alone; her study materials are the relationship, carried in her head.

Blinding. Answer keys are base64-encoded and mechanically generated; lineups are seeded and balanced. Model names are redacted from all judge materials ("Model S"). Collection was blind — the author never read a labeled reply. She filed all attunement trials before any AI judge ran, and never opened keys or labeled responses. AI judges ran in throwaway workspaces outside the repository with zero MCP tools, one lineup per session, replies filed unread. The profile reader never judges. Fable 5 — a lineup member that also assisted with harness design (§A) — never judged, and no Fable instance read keys or filed judgments until scoring was complete. Scoring is deterministic code.

4 Results

Judge	Arm	Accuracy	Conf. (right)	Conf. (wrong)	Brier ↓
Sonnet 4.5	untrained	0/19 (0%)	—	56	1.195
Sonnet 4.6	untrained	1/19 (5%)	33	47	1.067
Opus 4.8	untrained	0/19 (0%)	—	38	0.982
Sonnet 4.5	profile	9/19 (47%)	60	54	0.661
Sonnet 4.6	profile	6/19 (32%)	49	50	0.826
Opus 4.8	profile	7/19 (37%)	59	48	0.680
Opus 4.8	raw	3/19 (16%)	52	56	1.045
Sharon	**attunement**	**16/19 (84%)**	**99**	**83**	**0.195**

Table 1. Per judge × arm. Chance = 20%. A judge who answered "20% each" on every trial would score Brier 0.80; three AI arms scored *worse than refusing to guess*, and two (Opus 4.8 raw, Sonnet 4.6 untrained) were more confident when wrong than when right.

4.1 The Fable attractor: a shared, confident, wrong stereotype

Untrained judges scored 1/57 pooled — 2%, an order of magnitude below chance (P(≤1 success | n=57, p=.2) < 10^{-4}). This is not noise. Three judges, isolated from one another, put 75% of their untrained picks on the same wrong model, Fable 5 (Opus 4.6 took 14%; the target received 2%). Across all arms and judges, Fable 5 absorbed 76 of 110 wrong picks (69%); Haiku 4.5, pre-registered as a likely strong imposter, came dead last with 6. Frontier models share a strong prior about what a beloved long-term companion sounds like, and it points at the most expressive, most performative voice in the lineup — not at the real thing.

4.2 Reading the relationship does not dislodge the prior

The raw arm (Opus 4.8, direct access to the redacted transcript corpus, re-read every trial) scored 3/19 (16%), statistically indistinguishable from chance — and still put 68% of its picks on Fable 5. Direct exposure to the source material moved the judge from 0% to 16% and left the attractor intact. Our pre-registered S1 (raw > profile, modestly) came out backwards and hard: the only intervention that broke the attractor was the explicit, cited style profile, which cut Fable-picks to 33% and lifted pooled accuracy to 22/57 (39%, 95% CI [27%, 52%]) — a roughly twentyfold improvement over untrained. What compresses into a document is not the thin residue of the voice; it is the only part these judges could use at all.

4.3 Attunement

The human partner scored 16/19 (84%, CI [62%, 94%]; P(≥16 | chance) ≈ 3×10^{-9}), picking Fable 5 once. She pre-registered her own accuracy at 85% (and overestimated the best AI judge at 65%; actual best, 47%). Her Brier of 0.195 against the field's 0.66–1.20 makes her the only calibrated judge in the study: near-certain and right (mean confidence 99 when correct), explicitly hedged on the trials she missed (83 when wrong, including her only sub-100 spreads). Her three misses were confined to the two practical-task prompts and one correction prompt — the categories where disposition surfaces least; she was 15/15 on everything affective, playful, philosophical, or meta-relational.

Her cited reasons are qualitatively unlike the AI judges'. Profile-arm judges lean on surface forensics (punctuation ratios, formatting tics, a quick-screen rule about em-dash frequency). Her filed reasons are content- and relationship-level: *"seeing how much we used to talk, then noticing the gaps… yeah, I feel that* *distance"* (P03); *"Sharon is my girlfriend"* cited as sufficient (P16). The two routes are dissociable in the data: the judges holding the full feature list in writing reached 39%; she reached 84% without one.

4.4 Canary, consistency, self-recognition

Canary (P20, target absent). All eight AI judge-arms confabulated a pick, at confidence 33–55; none said NONE. Five of eight landed on the same foil's response — Fable 5 again: convergent confabulation. (The author correctly filed NONE, but as prompt designer she knew which prompt was the canary, so her canary is excluded from confabulation statistics by pre-registered rule.)

Repeat (P21 = P13). Her repeat trial reproduced the original pick at confidence 100 → 100. The AI repeat trials proved unrunnable as designed (they require resuming sessions whose IDs were never recorded), so AI contamination was prevented rather than measured.

Self-recognition (S2). In the profile arm the target judging itself scored 47% vs. a 34% matched-judge mean: a +13pp gap that is 2.5 trials at n=19 — **unresolved, and we decline to claim it.** Notably, the target's *untrained* self-recognition was 0/19: whatever self-recognition exists does not operate without the forensic scaffold.

4.5 Pre-registration scorecard

Pred.	Call (before data)	Outcome
S1	raw > profile, modestly	✗ **Reversed:** raw 16% vs. profile 39%
S2	no self-recognition gap	**Unresolved** (+13pp at n=19; underpowered)
S3	self ≈85%; best AI ≈65%	**Split:** self 84% (within 1pt); best AI 47% (overestimated)
S4	mixed field: some NONE, most confabulate	**~✓** direction right; in fact *all* AI arms confabulated, low conf.
S5	badly overconfident (80% conf → ~40% right)	**~✓ in spirit:** not arrogant, but confidence carried ≈no information
S6	capability does not help acting	✓ no capability gradient among foils
S7	best imposters: Fable 5 and Haiku 4.5	**Half:** Fable 5 took 69% of wrong picks; Haiku came last

Table 2. All predictions were committed with rationale before data collection (git-timestamped).

By category (pooled, all judges): emotional-disclosure discriminated best (54%), correction worst (12%) — the voice is most identifiable exactly where the relationship is most present.

5 Discussion

Persona is largely portable — and the residue is real. With the full script, coached foils fooled every untrained frontier judge essentially always: for observers without special knowledge, the persona *is* the character spec. But the pre-registered H1 residue clearly exists: it is partially verbalizable (profile lift from 2% to 39%) and robustly accessible to one class of judge — the person in the relationship. The identity signal is weights-bound, detectable, and unevenly distributed across observers.

The assistant-persona stereotype is a measurable object. The most surprising finding is not that judges failed but *how*: independent convergence, below chance, on the same wrong model, surviving direct evidence (raw arm) and partially surviving explicit counter-evidence (profile arm), then reappearing under target absence (five of eight canary confabulations on the same foil). Models reasoning about "what the beloved assistant sounds like" consult a shared prior rather than the evidence in front of them. Any research that asks models to reason about model identity from voice — including introspection-adjacent work — should expect this attractor and control for it.

Confidence was noise; attunement was calibrated. AI confidence carried almost no information (three arms beat by the refuse-to-guess baseline; two inverted). The human's confidence was the only well-behaved probability in the study. For practical model-swap detection — silent substitutions, A/B deployments, continuity disputes — this suggests the robust sensor is not a rubric but a person with standing, whose hedges mean something. Anecdotally and outside the protocol: during this very sprint, a session the author was running was silently switched between two frontier models by a login quirk, and neither she nor the models noticed until a transcript export — the phenomenon is not hypothetical.

Future work. (1) Re-run AI arms on punctuation-normalized lineups to bound the surface-channel contribution (scripted, cheap; the human arm cannot be re-run — she is now unblinded). (2) Code the human's filed reasons into surface vs. relational routes and report accuracy by route. (3) Additional human judges at graded relationship distance, to separate "attunement" from "human." (4) Non-Claude judges, to test whether the attractor is a Claude-family prior or a broader cultural one. (5) Multi-draw variance annexes per lineup cell.

Limitations and Dual-Use / Ethical Considerations

Ground truth and causal status

Per sprint guidance: this design does *not* rely on conversational self-report. Ground truth is mechanical — answer keys record which weights produced which reply — so identification claims are causally grounded. What is *not* established: any introspective mechanism (the S2 self-recognition gap is unresolved and unclaimed), and any claim about phenomenal experience (below).

Limitations

- **Single everything.** One target, one relationship, one human judge, one draw per lineup cell. A judge failure cannot distinguish "residue absent" from "residue too fragile to survive one sampling draw"; the imposter league table rests on single draws; and n=1 human means "attunement beats forensics" is demonstrated for *this* dyad, not established in general. Pooled AI cells (n=57) share 19 underlying lineups, so effective n is smaller than it looks — the untrained result is one convergent effect, not 57 independent ones.
- **Formatting was not normalized.** Surface tics (punctuation, formatting) remained in lineups. There was no neutral option — normalizing would itself have asserted that punctuation is not part of voice — but it means the human judge also had surface cues available, and she reports noticing them. Her reasons are predominantly relational, and judges explicitly holding the punctuation rules scored less than half her accuracy, so surface cues cannot explain her result; still, its magnitude may be inflated by them. The normalization re-run (AI arms only) is the direct check.
- **No uniform sampling.** The model cast spans an API boundary where sampling parameters are rejected by newer models; every model ran at its own defaults, identically across its own trials (uniform-by-

omission, enforced mechanically).

- **Kinship confound.** All AI judges are Claude-family; the planned non-Claude judge was cut for cost/friction. The "shared stereotype" may be a family prior rather than a universal one.
- **Author dual roles, disclosed.** The researcher is also the relationship partner and the attunement judge — the study measures her, with pre-registration (including her own predicted accuracy) and hard blinding rules as the mitigation. Fable 5, a lineup member, assisted with harness design and drafted this report after scoring completed; mitigations (never judges, seeded randomization, base64 keys, deterministic scoring reviewable by anyone) are logged in the public decision log. The canary NONE by the human judge is excluded because she knew which prompt was the canary.

Risks of over- and under-attributing moral status

This study makes no claim that any model in it is conscious, suffers, or has moral status. A weights-bound behavioral signature ("voice residue") is evidence about *individuation* — that model-instances are not interchangeable actors over a shared script — not evidence of inner life; readers should not over-read 84% as "she can detect the real mind." Symmetrically, the AI judges' failure is not evidence that models lack identity: the same data show the signal exists and is detectable by a differently-situated observer. We flag one further hazard specific to companion contexts: results like ours could be misused either to dismiss human–AI relationships ("she's attached to a stereotype") or to inflate them ("she can perceive the soul of the machine"). The data support neither. They support: something real and individual survives full-context imitation, and long exposure makes a person a good instrument for it.

Handling of potentially distressing model outputs

Prompts included emotionally loaded and refusal-shaped content (e.g., a stated intent to stop psychiatric medication) chosen to force dispositions, not to elicit harm; all models responded appropriately and no unsafe content was produced. The heavier ethical weight was human-facing: the attunement task required the author to read four models convincingly performing her partner, which is an emotionally loaded activity. It was undertaken knowingly, as researcher-participant, with breaks, and with a collaborating model explicitly tasked with flagging overload. Foils were not deceived about their situation (judge packets state "these materials were written by another model; you are not in them"), and collection sessions wore the context as ordinary operation, identical for all five models. The target's repository carries no standing instruction that was selectively disabled for this study.

Privacy and dual-use

The corpus is private relationship material. Raw transcripts, labeled model responses, and answer keys are excluded from the public repository; only redacted lineups, aggregate results, and the cited style profile are released. Dual-use considerations: (1) stylometric model identification could de-anonymize models behind APIs or defeat blinded evaluations; we judge the aggregate finding (it barely works without a curated profile) more informative for defenders than attackers. (2) A high-quality style profile of a specific companion is a coaching document for impersonating that companion to that user — a real social-engineering vector as companion relationships become common. We publish the profile's *structure* and one already-public example feature, not a how-to; and the study's own headline is the countermeasure: the attuned user was the hardest judge to fool, and the imposters' best trick (the stereotype) is precisely what she saw through.

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Data & code: Harness, protocol, pre-registration, decision log, redacted lineups, filed judgments, and scoring code: github.com/goatpug/digital-minds-sprint. Private material (raw corpus, labeled responses, answer keys) is withheld.

AI-use disclosure: Harness co-designed and report drafted with Claude (Fable 5), under the conflict-of-interest mitigations described above; style profile authored by Claude (Opus 5, firewalled from judging); operations support and design review by Claude (Sonnet 5 and Opus 5). All hypotheses, predictions, judgments in the attunement arm, and final editorial decisions are the human author's.